# Magdalena Wasilewska

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## Education

**University of Amsterdam** — Amsterdam, the Netherlands
PhD in Economics, Department of Microeconomics — September 2023 – present

- Supervisors: Prof. dr. Joël van der Weele and dr. Thomas Douenne
- Research stay at FAIR, NHH (hosted by Prof. Bertil Tungodden), February – April 2026

**KU Leuven** — Leuven, Belgium
MSc in Sociology (Social Data Science) — 2022 – 2023

**University of Amsterdam** — Amsterdam, the Netherlands
MSc in Economics (Behavioural Economics and Game Theory) — 2021 – 2022

**Warsaw School of Economics** — Warsaw, Poland
BSc in Quantitative Methods in Economics and Information Systems — 2017 – 2020

## Research Interests

Behavioral Economics, Experimental Economics, Public Economics, Political Economy

## References

**Prof. Joël van der Weele**
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**dr. Thomas Douenne**
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**Prof. Bertil Tungodden**
Norwegian School of Economics
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**Placement Director**
Prof. Eric Bartelsman
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## Job Market Paper

**Fairness at a Price: Support for Complex Benefit Systems**

Claiming welfare benefits involves substantial transaction costs. Simplifying benefit systems is on the policy agenda in many countries, but progress has been slow. I study whether public support can explain this, using a spectator experiment and a survey experiment in the Netherlands. Most spectators accept substantial effort costs on claimants for a modest improvement in targeting accuracy, but their support is sensitive to the size of these costs and falls when it fails to reach everyone it is meant for. In the survey experiment, information about the costs of complexity shifts respondents' beliefs but does not, on average, raise support for simplification. This average hides heterogeneity: respondents who have not received benefits become more supportive of a simpler system, whereas recipients do not, even though they update their beliefs at least as much and do not have more accurate priors at baseline. Across both experiments, support for simplification is thus sensitive to its costs among those who have nothing to lose from it. Building widespread support among the rest may therefore require resolving uncertainty about considerations people find salient when evaluating the reforms, such as how reform would affect their own entitlements.

## Working Papers

**Do People Distinguish Income from Wealth Inequality? Evidence from the Netherlands**
with Thomas Douenne, Oda Sund and Joël van der Weele · ***R&R at The Economic Journal***

In most countries, wealth inequality is much higher than income inequality, spurring debates about wealth taxation. However, it is unclear if voters are aware of these differences. In a large-scale survey experiment among a representative Dutch population (N=4,501), we study voters' perceptions of income and wealth distributions, and connect their views to administrative data about their own income and wealth. Despite a primer on the definition of income and wealth, respondents underestimate the difference between the top 10% share of income and wealth by a factor of 10. Moreover, they use information about the income distribution to make predictions about the wealth distribution and vice versa, even when information about both is provided, further demonstrating confusion about the two types of inequality. An information intervention about actual inequality levels and personal ranks in the income/wealth distribution has an impact on the perceived inequality and perceived fairness of inequality, but little effect on policy preferences. We discuss implications for political debates about inequality and wealth taxation.

## Work in Progress

**Inequality Narratives and Redistribution**
with Thomas Douenne, Oda Sund and Joël van der Weele

How do people explain economic inequality, and how do these personal narratives shape responses to narratives provided by others? We field two linked surveys on representative samples of the Dutch population, conducted two years apart and linked to administrative tax data, and document three findings. First, open-ended "top-of-mind" explanations show that most respondents attribute inequality to structural factors (the labor market, family background, education, and the tax system) rather than effort or luck, and that these narratives vary with wealth, political identity, and fairness views. Second, linking the surveys, narratives independently predict redistributive preferences two years later, as well as which narratives respondents expose themselves to when given a choice. Third, experimentally provided narratives shift emotions and beliefs about the meritocracy of education, but not redistributive attitudes; updating is constrained by prior beliefs, and counter-attitudinal expert narratives can even backfire. Inequality narratives are thus durable elements of worldviews, robust to short-run interventions.

**Salience and Meritocracy**

## Teaching and Supervision

**Economics (in a Global Business World)** 2023 – present
Teaching Assistant, BSc Business Administration, University of Amsterdam

**Master and Bachelor Thesis Supervision** 2023 – present
20 BSc theses (Economics and Business Economics; PPLE), 1 MSc thesis (Economics)

## Grants

*Fairness at a Price: Support for Complex Benefit Systems*
Amsterdam Center for Behavioral Change (ACBC) €10 000
A Sustainable Future (ASF) Initiative €9 200
Amsterdam Centre for European Studies (ACES) €2 500

*Inequality Narratives and Redistribution* (with T. Douenne, O. Sund and J. van der Weele)
LISS panel grant (Principal Investigator) approx. €10 000
Amsterdam Center for Behavioral Change (ACBC) approx. €7 000

*Do People Distinguish Income from Wealth Inequality?* (with T. Douenne, O. Sund and J. van der Weele)
Amsterdam Centre for European Studies (ACES) approx. €5 000

## Presentations

**2026:** 18th Nordic Conference in Behavioral and Experimental Economics, Helsinki; World Inequality Conference, Paris; BÆM Meeting on Fairness in the Economy, Bristol; Bergen-Berlin Behavioural Workshop, Bergen; Pizza & Presentation Seminar, FAIR NHH, Bergen

**2025:** Workshop on Psychological and Economic Perspectives on Inequality, Amsterdam; Workshop in Behavioral Public Economics and Political Economy, Vienna; Narratives, Memory and Beliefs Summer School and Workshop, Riederau; Text as Data in Behavioral Economics, Potsdam; CBESS-CeDEx-CREED Meeting (CCC), Amsterdam; MPI-CREED Meeting, Bonn

**2024:** Interdisciplinary Brownbag Seminar of Behavioral Sciences, Maastricht; Max Planck Summer School on the Political Economy of Conflict and Redistribution, Berlin; 23rd Journées Louis-André Gérard-Varet (LAGV), Marseille; 7th Maastricht Behavioral Economic Policy Symposium (M-BEPS), Maastricht; CBESS-CeDEx-CREED Meeting (CCC), Norwich

## Service

- Organiser of the CREED lunch seminar
- Co-organiser of the CBESS-CeDEx-CREED Meeting

## Skills

**Languages** Polish (native), English (fluent), French (beginner), Dutch (beginner)
**Software** Stata, R, Python, LaTeX